

Definitions from the Wisconsin DNR

Exceptional:
“Surface waters that provide outstanding recreational opportunities, support valuable fisheries and wildlife habitat, have good water quality are not significantly impacted by human activities”

Exceptional Waters Include:

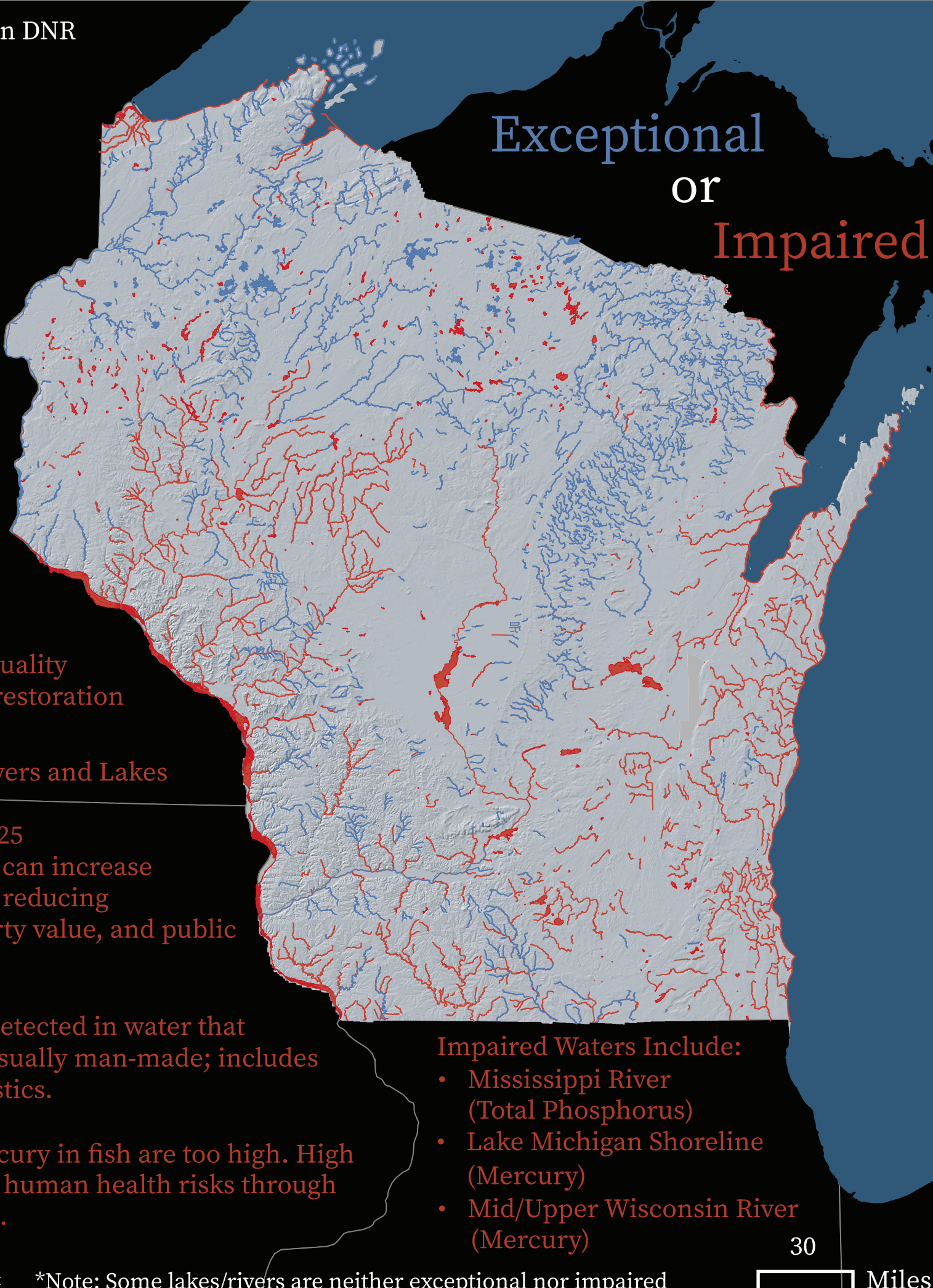
- Devils Lake
- Lake Superior (Island Shorelines)
- Wolf River
- St. Croix River
- Lower Wisconsin River

Impaired:
“Waters not attaining water quality standards that do not have a restoration plan in place”

Most Common Problems - Rivers and Lakes Combined:

1. High Phosphorus Levels: 825
 - A. High phosphorus levels can increase plant and algae growth, reducing recreational use, property value, and public health
2. Unknown Pollutant: 235
 - A. Unknown compounds detected in water that lack safety standards. Usually man-made; includes PFAS, PPCP's, microplastics.
3. Mercury: 173
 - A. Often, the levels of mercury in fish are too high. High mercury in fish leads to human health risks through the consumption of fish.

Exceptional
or
Impaired



- Impaired Waters Include:
- Mississippi River (Total Phosphorus)
 - Lake Michigan Shoreline (Mercury)
 - Mid/Upper Wisconsin River (Mercury)